

## **Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)**

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# Job

## Job

When we experience suffering, we often ask why. Some people say suffering happens because the person did something wrong. The book of Job questions that idea. It tells about Job, a man who suffered even though he was blameless.

Job's friends thought he must have done some hidden sin. They urged him to repent, or turn back to God. But Job knew he had not sinned in that way, so he questioned God.

At last, God appeared to Job. But God did not give Job the answers he wanted. Instead, God helped Job see things in a new way. Then God blessed him.

## Setting

The book of Job takes place early in the patriarchal age. This was the time of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, before Israel became a nation. Job's wealth was like Abraham's wealth. It was measured in livestock and servants (1:3; 42:12; see Genesis 12:16; 32:5).

Job also served as priest for his family. A priest offers worship and sacrifices to God. This was common before God gave the law of Moses (1:5; 42:8; see Genesis 4:4; 8:20; 12:7–8; 13:18; 15:9–10; 26:25; 33:20; 35:1–6; 46:1).

In Job's time, the Sabeans and Chaldeans were groups who moved from place to place and attacked others (1:15, 17). They were not yet powerful nations with strong political and economic control, as they were later in Israel's history (compare Isaiah 45:14; Joel 3:8).

Job and his relatives used money called the kesitah ("a piece of silver" in the Berean Standard Bible; 42:11). People used this kind of money during the patriarchal age (see Genesis 33:19; Joshua 24:32).

Job also lived a very long life. Only people who lived before the flood and the patriarchs lived as long as, or longer than, Job (Genesis 1–6; 42:16; see 5:3–32; 25:7; 35:28; 47:28; 50:26). Through Job, readers return to the beginning of human history. They see how people first struggled to know God and understand the world.

## Summary

The prose introduction to Job is found in chapters 1–2. It shows the heavenly view of Job's suffering. It also prepares the way for the human dialogue that makes up most of the book.

Job was a righteous man. God allowed Satan to test him. In the heavenly courtroom, Satan said Job served God only because God had blessed him. Satan argued that if God took away those blessings, Job would "surely curse You to Your face" (1:11).

But Job did not curse God. Instead, he said, "Blessed be the name of the LORD" (1:21). Later he said, "Should we accept from God only good and not adversity?" (2:10). In this way, Job showed that God's praise of him was true.

The scene then moves from the court of heaven to a human council. Three of Job's friends come to show sympathy for him. For seven days, they sit with Job in silence. This seems to be a sincere effort to comfort him (2:11–13). But when Job speaks and shares his bitter complaint, his friends begin to criticize and condemn him (chapter 3). They debate with Job in three rounds of speeches (chapters 4–27). Their words move from hints of blame to direct accusations.

Job's friends make a strict theological argument. They say God is righteous, so he gives each person what that person deserves. For this reason, they believe Job's suffering must be a just punishment for some evil he has done. Job answers each speech by saying that he is innocent. He insists that his suffering is not deserved and is not fair.

After Job and his friends finish their three rounds of dialogue, a poetic section praises God as the only source of wisdom (chapter 28). Job then gives his final speech. He speaks about his misery and also defends his righteousness (chapters 29–31). After this, his three friends stop answering him (32:1).

Then Elihu speaks. He is a new voice in the book. Elihu continues the human struggle to explain why Job is suffering (chapters 32–37). Finally, God comes to challenge Job (chapters 38–41). God does not answer Job's case directly. Instead, God asks Job many questions. These questions show God's power and rule over all things. Job responds with repentance. He admits that he does not have the right to question God in this way (42:1–6).

In the final prose section, God again confirms that Job is righteous and faithful (42:7–17). God also judges Job's friends because they did not speak rightly about him. Then God greatly blesses Job.

## Job as History

The heavenly setting at the start of Job and God's appearance at the end may lead some people today to see the book as a fictional parable.

The poetic dialogues also show that Job is more than a simple historical record. But history can be told through poetry as well as through detailed narrative (see Exodus 14:21–31; 15:1–12; Psalms 78; 105).

Other parts of the Bible suggest that Job was a historical person. The prophet Ezekiel and the apostle James both refer to Job as an example of “righteousness” and “perseverance” (Ezekiel 14:14, 20; James 5:11).

## Author and Date of Composition

The author and writing history of Job are not clear. The story takes place in the patriarchal age, around 2000 BC. This was the time of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. But the book itself may have been written much later.

Scholars have suggested many possible dates. Some place it during Israel’s wilderness journey, the time described in Exodus through Numbers. Others place it after the return from exile, the time described in Ezra and Nehemiah.

The final form of Job was probably completed during the time of the monarchy, when kings ruled Israel and Judah. This is the time described in 1–2 Kings. During this period, other wisdom writings, such as Proverbs and Ecclesiastes, were also being collected.

Even if Job was a historical person, we still do not know who wrote the book. We also do not know where the author lived or what place he had in society.

The author seems to have been a wise teacher. He knew how to use proverbs (short sayings that teach wisdom; for example, 4:2; 6:5–6). He also knew how to use rhetorical questions (questions asked to make a point; for example, 21:29). He was skilled in clear and powerful speech. The author also knew about plants, animals, foreign cultures, and ancient history. This included knowledge of the patriarchal period.

The date of Job cannot be known with certainty. The book does not give clear evidence from the events or people it mentions. The earliest other biblical reference to Job comes during the exile (Ezekiel 14:14, 20). The book also cannot be dated with certainty from its teachings about God. These ideas do not point clearly to one time period. Its connection to other Old Testament texts also does not give a certain date (for example, compare 3:3–10; Jeremiah 20:14–18). Job may even have been edited over time by several different people.

## Literary Characteristics

### Ancient Parallels to Job

The book of Job is similar in some ways to other writings from the ancient Near East. The ancient Near East was the region around Israel, including places such as Mesopotamia and Egypt.

The following list of parallels is based on James B. Pritchard, editor, *Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament*, 3rd edition (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1969):

- The Canaanite story called the “Legend of King Keret” tells about a king who loses his family through several natural disasters. Then his god, El, restores his family.
- The Egyptian document “Dispute over Suicide” (2000s BC) describes a man thinking about suicide. He hopes someone will present his case to the heavenly council. (While Job wishes he had never been born, he does not think about suicide.)
- Also from Egypt, “Protests of the Eloquent Peasant” (2200s BC) tells about a man who was robbed and was not treated justly. He appeals to local leaders. At first, he speaks politely. But as he continues to present his case, his words become stronger and more forceful.
- The Babylonian story called “I Will Praise the Lord of Wisdom” tells about a faithful man with high social rank. He becomes sick, and his friends mock him. Unlike Job, this man believes he may have sinned by accident. He may have done something wrong without knowing it was wrong. He does not insist that he is innocent. Instead, he admits his guilt and asks for mercy.

After several exorcisms (rituals meant to remove evil spirits) the man is healed. Then his god restores his wealth and well-being. The man responds with thanks. He ends the story with a long song of praise to his god.

- The Babylonian writing called the “Babylonian Theodicy” also has a dialogue form like Job. A theodicy is an attempt to explain why suffering exists if the gods, or God, are just.

In this writing, the sufferer complains. His friends answer him with correction and blame. The arguments on both sides are very similar to the arguments in Job. But there are also important differences:

1. The “Babylonian Theodicy” is polytheistic. This means it speaks about many gods. Job is monotheistic. This means it speaks about one God.
2. The sufferer in the “Babylonian Theodicy” threatens to leave his faith and stop obeying. Yet he ends by asking his god and goddess for help. Job remains

faithful to the Lord throughout his suffering (for example, Job 13:15–16).

### Relationship to Israel's Wisdom Literature

The book of Job is similar to other Old Testament wisdom writings. Job's friends use ideas found in Deuteronomy, Chronicles, and Proverbs. They argue that wisdom and righteousness lead to life and success. They also argue that foolishness and wickedness lead to death and failure.

But Job questions this simple way of thinking. Ecclesiastes also raises similar questions. Both books show that this teaching cannot be applied in the same way to every person or every situation.

### Meaning and Message

The book of Job does not explain why people suffer. That is not its purpose. But it does show that suffering is not always God's punishment for sin. Job does not receive an answer about why bad things happen to righteous people. We do not receive a full answer either.

The main conflict in Job is about the integrity of both God the Creator and Job the man. God's integrity means that God is always right and faithful. Job's integrity means that Job is honest and faithful to God. Heaven and earth seem to be in conflict.

It is easy to agree with Job's three friends and deny that Job is innocent. Some New Testament passages say that no human being is righteous apart from God's grace (for example, Romans 3:10, 23; Luke 18:19). But Job's righteousness is real. At the same time, he becomes very focused on proving that he is right. At times, this comes close to self-righteousness, or trusting too much in his own goodness. He becomes so strong in defending himself that he seems almost ready to defy God.

Job's three friends present a view of God that seems more orthodox, or more in line with accepted teaching, at least at first. These counselors are not weak or imaginary opponents. They explain many biblical ways of thinking about suffering.

But they apply these ideas wrongly. They assume too much. They insist that God always gives people exactly what they have earned. In their view, every good or bad thing that happens to a person is a direct result of what that person deserves.

The book of Job follows the basic beliefs of Israel's faith in the Old Testament. Job and the other speakers take seriously the covenant (God's binding agreement with his people). They believe that God blesses obedi-

ence and judges disobedience (Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 28). They also believe that people often receive the results of their actions in this life (Psalm 34:11–22; see also Galatians 6:7; 1 Peter 3:10).

The speakers do not look for answers outside biblical teaching. For example, they do not use dualism (the belief that two equal powers of good and evil rule the world), polytheism (belief in many gods), or naturalism (the belief that only the material world exists). Instead, they seek answers that fit with Scripture.

They explain suffering in several ways:

- It may be punishment for sin (for example, Job 4:7–9).
- It may be part of human life, because people are weak and tend toward sin (for example, 15:14–16).
- It may be God's discipline, which means his correction and training (for example, 5:17–18; 33:15–28; 36:8–15; see Proverbs 3:11; Hebrews 12:2–13).
- It may be part of God's mysterious plan (for example, Job 11:7–8; 37:19, 23).
- Or it may be a test on earth that answers a question raised in heaven (for example, 1:6–12).

Life "under the sun" means life in this world, as Ecclesiastes describes it. This view is too small to answer all the great questions. So the writer of Job points to heaven to show that events on earth have a deeper meaning. But even in heaven, God does not give the full answer. The book does not explain why God allowed Satan's challenge at the beginning.

In the end, the book of Job shows that God defends Job as innocent. God also rejects simple answers about suffering. But God does not answer all of Job's questions. Job could not understand the whole created world. Because of this, he could not demand a full explanation of how his suffering fit into God's order. The world is larger and more complex than human beings can fully understand.

The book of Job gives a complex picture of God. God could have rejected Satan's challenge because he had nothing to prove. Yet God chose to allow the test. In the end, God shows his power and defeats Satan through Job's faithfulness. God never explains to Job what was happening in heaven. Instead, God challenges Job's right to question whether God's justice is right and trustworthy (40:8).

The way to live through suffering is not simply trying to stay strong. Instead, we should humbly honor God and trust his wise and good rule. When suffering comes, people can respond to God by worshiping him. They can also trust that God's ways are wise and just, even when the pain is severe and the confusion

is deep. God's holy purposes for human suffering are sometimes hidden.

In the end, Job comes closer to God through his suffering. He says, "My ears had heard of You, but now my eyes have seen You" (42:5).